

OTA Inbox Response Checklist

Booking.com | Expedia | Airbnb | Vrbo — Message Handling Standards

Use this checklist to standardise how your team or external support partners manage OTA inboxes. Consistent, fast, policy-aligned responses improve your OTA ranking, reduce booking friction, and prevent complaints from surfacing in reviews.

< 30 min

Pre-booking target
Highest conversion window

< 60 min

Post-booking target
Affects review sentiment

< 15 min

Complaint target
Escalate immediately

1. Inbox Setup and Access

Confirm these are in place before any team member or partner handles OTA messages.

- ☐ Booking.com Message Center login credentials are documented and accessible to all authorised handlers.
- ☐ Expedia Partner Central inbox access is set up for all authorised users.
- ☐ Airbnb account access is granted to the messaging team via Co-Host or shared credentials as appropriate.
- ☐ Vrbo / VRBO inbox access is confirmed and tested.
- ☐ Notification settings on each platform are configured so new messages trigger an alert, not just a daily summary.
- ☐ Response-time metrics are reviewed in each platform at least weekly.

2. Pre-Booking Inquiries

These are the highest-priority messages. A delay here costs a booking.

- ☐ All pre-booking questions are answered within your defined response target (typically under 30 minutes).
- ☐ Availability questions: agent checks live availability before confirming, not from memory.
- ☐ Rate questions: agent quotes the correct rate for the requested dates, including any OTA-specific promotion or non-refundable option.
- ☐ Facility and accessibility questions are answered accurately from the property brief, not guessed.
- ☐ Policy questions (pets, smoking, early check-in) are answered based on the current written policy.

- ☐ If a question cannot be answered directly, it is acknowledged within target time and escalated with a timeline given to the guest.
- ☐ Response is written in the guest's language where the OTA provides an auto-translation prompt, or escalated if language is not covered.

3. Post-Booking Guest Messages

Questions from confirmed guests. Accuracy and tone are both important here.

- ☐ Check-in instructions: template is current and matches the actual check-in process.
- ☐ Arrival time inquiries are handled within the platform, not deferred to phone or email.
- ☐ Special request messages (cot, high floor, anniversary) are logged in PMS and confirmed to the guest.
- ☐ Questions about charges or invoices are answered based on the booking record, not estimated.
- ☐ Repeat messages from the same guest (a guest who has messaged twice without a reply) are flagged as urgent.

4. Modification and Cancellation Requests

Handle within the platform where possible. Never process outside OTA without authorisation.

- ☐ Date change requests are handled within the OTA platform using the correct modification flow, not via direct payment or third-party arrangement.
- ☐ Cancellation requests within the refund window: confirm the policy, process within platform, confirm to guest.
- ☐ Cancellation requests outside the refund window: acknowledge, explain policy, log, and escalate to GM for any exception decisions.
- ☐ No refund or exception is offered without explicit GM or owner authorisation.
- ☐ Any modification that changes the rate must be reviewed against current pricing before confirmation.
- ☐ OTA-side modifications are confirmed in PMS to keep records aligned.

5. Complaint Handling

How complaints are handled on OTA messaging directly affects review outcomes.

- ☐ Complaints are acknowledged within 15 minutes — acknowledgement alone, not resolution, within that window.
- ☐ Agent empathises and confirms they are looking into the issue before providing any resolution.
- ☐ Minor complaints (housekeeping, noise, missing item) are handled directly with an apology and a concrete action taken.

- ☐ Serious complaints (safety, significant property issue, health concern) are escalated to management immediately via call, not held in OTA message thread.
- ☐ No compensation, refund, or upgrade is offered without authorisation.
- ☐ Resolution is followed up in the same OTA message thread once actioned, so the guest has a record.
- ☐ Every complaint is logged regardless of how it was resolved, as it may precede a negative review.

6. Review Responses

Responses to guest reviews on Booking.com and Expedia are public. Tone matters more here than anywhere else.

- ☐ All reviews (positive and negative) receive a management response within 48 hours.
- ☐ Positive reviews: thank the guest by first name, reference one specific thing they mentioned, invite them back.
- ☐ Negative reviews: do not argue or be defensive. Acknowledge the experience, apologise for the shortfall, note the action taken.
- ☐ Review responses are never written in anger or immediately after reading a negative review.
- ☐ No private guest information (booking details, names, complaint specifics) is included in a public review response.
- ☐ Response drafts for serious negative reviews are reviewed by GM before posting.

7. Direct Booking Conversion

Where appropriate, conversations naturally point guests toward direct booking for future stays.

- ☐ At the end of a pre-booking inquiry that converts to a booking through the OTA: note the direct booking option for future stays without pressing on the current booking.
- ☐ Post-checkout follow-up messages (where OTA allows) include a mention of direct booking advantages (e.g., flexible rate, direct perks).
- ☐ Direct booking nudges are natural and never pushy — the OTA relationship is not put at risk.

8. Escalation Triggers — Act Immediately

- ☐ Medical or safety concern mentioned by guest.
- ☐ Guest has not received expected check-in information and arrival is within 2 hours.
- ☐ Complaint involving a threat to leave a review if not compensated.
- ☐ OTA platform has flagged your response-time metric as at risk.
- ☐ Guest claims they were overcharged or double-billed.

☐ Message involves a regulatory or legal concern (discrimination claim, injury).

☐ Guest has not received a reply to two or more messages within target time.

Want GuestSquad to manage your OTA inboxes?

guestsquad.com/services/ota-inbox-management